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November 8 — The Baptism and Temptation of Jesus

Lesson 01 - The Baptism and Temptation of Jesus

Aim: Learn about Jesus and let his example shape the people we are becoming.

Introduction

I'm looking forward to spending time with you learning about and *from* the life of Jesus. We don't just want to get to know what he did, what mattered to him, and how he treated people. We also want to understand what that tells about God wants all of his children to think and live.

Before we get started this morning I want to read two short passages together:

- 2 Timothy 3:15–17: Scripture leads us toward salvation through faith in Christ. It teaches, corrects, and trains us so that we are equipped to do good. God is preparing us for something we will actually do.
- Romans 12:1–2: In response to God's mercy, we offer our lives to him. We are to be transformed through renewed minds, learning to recognize and choose his will. As we listen to God's word, we want it to change the way we think.

**What I want you to notice is that the goal of studying the Bible isn't just to know things; it's to become a new kind of person.* As we learn about Jesus together over the next few months, the challenge is to use what we learn to to become more like him.*

How class will work each Sunday

1. **Warm up:** Share a recent win or highlight, a current struggle or challenge, and something we're looking forward to.
2. **Read the Scripture around:** Take turns reading and make sure we understand what the passage says.
3. **Read the lesson around:** Take turns reading and make sure we understand what the lesson says.
4. **Lessons for us:** Discuss why these things matter, what they show us about God and Jesus, and how they can change our lives.

During the two readings, start with understanding the words and following the account. Keep the bigger questions about why, meaning, and application for the discussion. Jot those

questions down so we can return to them.

Warm up

Each of us can share...

- A recent win or highlight.
- A current struggle or challenge.
- Something you're looking forward to.

If you don't have all 3, that's OK. If you're uncomfortable offering any, just say pass. I'll go first to give you an idea of what it looks like.

Read the Scripture around

Main reading: Matthew 3 and Matthew 4:1–11. These are the passages named in the lesson. Read online — stop at Matthew 4:11.

Take turns reading a few verses each. Pause at these natural breaks:

- **Matthew 3:1–12:** John's message and the people who came to him.
- **Matthew 3:13–17:** Jesus' baptism and the response from heaven.
- **Matthew 4:1–4:** The wilderness, hunger, and the first temptation.
- **Matthew 4:5–11:** The remaining temptations, Jesus' replies, and what happened afterward.

Focus: What does the passage say? Use these as needed:

- Where is John, and what does he tell people to do?
- What does John say when Jesus comes to be baptized? What does Jesus reply?
- What happens immediately after Jesus' baptism?
- What is Jesus asked to do in each temptation? How does he answer?
- What happens at the end of the temptations?

Clarify unfamiliar words and who is speaking. Ask students to point to the verse that supports an answer. Save the reasons behind Jesus' choices and the connections to our lives for later.

Read the lesson around

Return to Lesson 01 - The Baptism and Temptation of Jesus. Take turns reading paragraphs, pausing at section breaks to check understanding.

Focus: What does the lesson say?

- What does it say John was preparing people for?
- What does it say Jesus demonstrated by being baptized?
- Which book of Scripture did Jesus use in his replies to temptation? Which earlier events does the lesson connect with his experiences?
- What does it recommend we do to prepare for temptation?

Keep these answers descriptive: “The lesson says…” Note questions or claims we want to examine during the discussion. The reference library and end questions can be used as follow-up rather than read aloud.

Lessons for us

The first three discussions develop the ideas in the November 7 planning transcript. The fourth draws out the lesson's emphasis on overcoming temptation. Use the prompts that help the conversation; they aren't a checklist to finish.

1. Learn to notice where God is working

Read Luke 3:1–2 as a short supplement to Matthew's account. Luke names an emperor, governors, rulers, and high priests, then tells us that God's word came to John in the wilderness.

The people with the most attention and influence aren't necessarily the people who help us see what God is doing. God was preparing people for Jesus through John. Fame doesn't tell us how much someone's life matters to God's purpose.

Discuss:

- If you were living then, whose activities might have seemed most important? What does Luke draw our attention to?
- Sports, politics, and entertainment receive a lot of attention today. How can that affect what we think matters?
- Where could we pay more attention to someone quietly serving God, or to an opportunity to serve him ourselves?

Bring it home: We don't need to be famous to take part in God's work. Pay attention to God and to the people and opportunities he has put near us.

2. Obedience makes us available to God's purpose

Matthew 3:13–17, especially Jesus' answer in verse 15. The lesson emphasizes his willingness to do what was right before God, even though he was sinless.

There's something deeper about Jesus' obedience than simply that he did what God told him to do. Jesus understood that God's commands have a purpose.

Through obedience...

- we honor God and show our love for him,
  - when you pay attention and respond to someone, you show them you care about them
- we learn to care about what he cares about, and
  - God's commands reflect how he thinks and feels, so our obedience gives us the opportunity to learn to think and feel like he does
- we make ourselves available for him to work through us
  - God is working a plan to set the world right and obedience allows us to be part of that work. It begins to set things right in us, which makes us useful to God's work of setting things right around us.

> **Note**
> We may see how a choice changes us without seeing all the ways God uses it to help others. Understanding the whole outcome isn't a prerequisite for trusting him.

Discuss:

- What does Jesus' willingness to be baptized show us about his attitude toward his Father?
- How could telling the truth, keeping a promise, or including someone shape us and also help someone else?
- What can help us choose obedience when we can't see what good will come from it?

Bring it home: Choose one ordinary act of obedience this week. Consider what it expresses about our love for God and the kind of person he is helping us become.

3. Faithful living includes repentance and forgiveness

Return to Matthew 3:6–8 and the lesson's call to repentance. When the lesson speaks about obeying God's commands with faith and love, remember the transcript's point: acknowledging sin and seeking forgiveness belong within that response to God.

Read 1 John 1:8–2:2. John calls us to avoid sin, to be honest about our failures, and to seek the forgiveness God provides through Jesus. Faithfulness doesn't mean claiming we have lived flawlessly. It means continuing to turn toward God, confessing when we fall short, and seeking his help to change.

Discuss:

- What is the difference between making excuses for a wrong choice and repenting of it?
- Suppose someone joins in mocking a classmate. What could confession, making amends, and a changed response look like?
- How does knowing that God provides forgiveness help us be honest and keep trying?

Bring it home: When we fail, acknowledge it, ask forgiveness, put things right where we can, and ask for help to act differently. Our hope rests in God's mercy through Jesus as we learn to follow him, not on flawless obedience.

4. Let God's word shape our response to temptation

Matthew 4:1–11. The CSSA lesson connects Jesus' replies with Deuteronomy 8:3, 6:16, and 6:13. He brought God's word to bear on the choices in front of him.

- **Stones into bread:** A real need doesn't make every way of meeting it right. Learn to trust God when we feel pressure to satisfy ourselves immediately.
- **Jump from the temple:** Trusting God doesn't mean creating a crisis to make him prove that he cares for us.
- **The kingdoms of the world:** Something attractive or powerful isn't worth turning away from God to obtain.

The tempter also quoted Scripture. Jesus' response reminds us to understand God's word in context and let it direct our choices. Knowing a verse becomes useful as we learn to live by it.

Discuss:

- When might we be tempted to do something wrong because we want something now, want to impress people, or want to get ahead?
- Choose one example. What truth from today's reading could help us respond differently?
- What could help us remember that truth before the moment becomes difficult?

Encouragement: Hebrews 4:15–16 tells us that Jesus understands temptation and directs us to seek mercy and help. We can ask for God's help while learning from Jesus' example.

Closing

Return to the purpose of the class: learning from Jesus should equip us to live differently.

Invite each person to finish: **“One thing I want to remember or practice this week is…”**
They can keep their answer private if they prefer.